

(1) Lutheran Church

BRIEF INTRODUCTION

The Lutheran Church (Lutheranism) is a major Protestant denomination with approximately 70-80 million (2014 estimates) members (often called Lutherans) worldwide. Lutheranism is founded by German Roman Catholic monk Martin Luther (1483-1546), whose efforts in early sixteenth century (1517 CE) to reform (from errors and abuse) the theology and practice of the Roman Catholic Church initiated the Protestant Reformation.

Lutheranism (i.e. Protestantism) began as a separate movement splitting from Roman Catholicism with the 'Edict of Worms' (declared Luther and his teachings as heretic and banned aiding and supporting him or his teachings) in 1521 CE. Officially Lutheranism would become known as a separate movement after the 'Diet of Augsburg' in 1530 CE. Lutheranism soon spread throughout Germany and northern Europe (Norway, Sweden, Finland, Iceland, and Denmark) getting acceptance and support from local princes and rulers.

Lutheranism was brought to America when Lutherans from these countries began to migrate to north America in the 17th century. Later on Lutheranism spread to Australia, Africa and Asia through migration, colonization and evangelism. Today (2014 CE) Lutheranism is the official state religion of Norway, Sweden, Denmark, Finland and Iceland. Lutheranism is the religion of the majority of the population in Namibia, Latvia and Germany (along with Roman Catholicism).

Luther's intention was never to start a separate movement but rid the Catholic Church of its errors and abuse and bring it back to a faith based on Biblical teaching. Hence whenever possible Luther in his reform kept the Roman Catholic position and practice as long as it didn't contradict or seem to be totally unfounded according to Bible. This is why Lutheran Churches resemble the Roman Catholic Church more than any other Protestant denominations.

In our following discussion we will focus only on unique aspects of Lutheranism and where there are differences with other Protestant denominations. So it is important to read upon 'Branches of Christianity' and 'Protestantism' in our website before proceeding any further.

SOURCES OF RELIGIOUS/SACRED INFORMATION

Lutheranism (like all other Protestant denominations) only considers the holy Bible as the source of religious/sacred information.

Lutheranism also accepts "Book of Concord" as a source of religious information with high esteem as it relates teachings from Bible authored by Luther and Philipp Melanchthon.

KEY FEATURES OF BELIEF

(Only the unique features of Lutheranism are discussed in this section)

THE CHURCH

There is a good amount of diversity when it comes to church governance within Lutheran Churches. Many Lutheran churches (mostly in Europe) use Episcopal form while some other use Congregational or Presbyterian form of church governance.

Many Lutheran churches tend to reflect the appearance, atmosphere and liturgical structure of Roman Catholic church. For example, most Lutheran churches have altars, and their clergy wear vestments similar to those worn by Roman Catholic priests.

THE CLERGY

Today most Lutheran churches allow women to be part of the clergy. Many Lutheran Churches nowadays also ordain homosexual clergy.

THE SACRAMENTS (OR ORDINANCES)

Lutherans accept two sacraments: Baptism and Holy Communion.

Baptism: Lutherans baptize both infants and adults. They believe Baptism is a once-in-a-lifetime event, thus people with valid baptisms (all baptisms performed in the name of the triune God) from other denominations (such as Catholics, Anglicans, Presbyterians, Methodists, etc.) may not be baptized again upon conversion.

Holy Communion: The Lutheran Church teaches that in the Holy Communion, Christ's body and blood are given in, with and under the bread and the wine. Lutherans stress the real bodily presence of Christ (known as the sacramental union) in the sacrament. They traditionally use bread and wine in the celebration of the Holy Communion and communicants normally receive both bread and wine.

WORSHIP AND PRAYER

Lutheranism retains altars, vestments and a certain order in worship (liturgy) structure of Roman Catholicism with the understanding that no church was bound to follow any particular order. Importance is given on Bible readings, preaching and congregational singing during service.

SALVATION

Lutherans believe falling away (loss of salvation) is possible by disbelief (blasphemy or not persisting in faith).

STATUES AND ICONS (IMAGES)

Lutherans do not totally object use of religious statues and objects. Hence there is limited use of statues and images in Lutheran churches.

CONTRACEPTION AND CONCEPTION

Historically opposed contraception but in modern times some Lutheran churches allow some sort of contraception, some oppose and some have no official position.

ABORTION

There is no unified position among all Lutheran churches. Some Lutheran churches allow abortion under certain circumstances and some do not allow abortion except in case of 'life of mother'.

DIVORCE AND REMARRIAGE

Lutheran churches allow divorce and remarriage under certain circumstances.

FOR MORE INFORMATION (Some Sources Used For This Article)

<http://www.patheos.com/Library/Lutheran>
http://www.lutheran-resources.org/lutheran_beliefs.htm
<https://www.elca.org/en/Faith/ELCA-Teaching>
<http://www.lcms.org/belief-and-practice>
<http://www.lca.org.au/what-lutherans-believe-3.html>
<http://bookofconcord.org/lc-1-intro.php>